Go-to-market

Ninety days from an unproven marketplace to one completed property transaction, with the buy side recruited before a single seller is marketed to.

LAUNCH CITY	90-DAY BUDGET	FIRST COMPLETION
Birmingham	**£16,996**	**Day 76**
Locked until three completions	Itemised, incl. 15% contingency	First revenue day 34

Issued 18 August 2026 · Internal operating plan · Figures are screening estimates and current UK list prices, not advice. Statutory fees marked † must be verified before commitment.

This plan is constrained by two things the codebase already decided, and it is better for both.

1. The thesis in one paragraph

Capital is not scarce. UK bridging lending runs at several billion a year and every lender is hunting deal flow. **Qualified deals are scarce.** So Lode is a supply-constrained marketplace, and every pound of early spend goes to deal supply — with one hard precondition: the buy side must be pre-committed first, because `countInterestedBuyers()` reads live mandates and **the product will not let us tell a seller that buyers exist when they do not.** That constraint is the moat. Every competitor's "47 buyers waiting!" is a number in a CMS. Ours is a database query, and it returns zero until we do the work.

2. The constraint that inverts the obvious strategy

The instinct in motivated-seller acquisition is to target maximum distress. Run the numbers the engine actually holds:

Seller situation	Motivation	Engine verdict
Repossession proceedings	96	**Blocked** — vulnerability flag
Urgent cash requirement	92	**Blocked** — vulnerability flag
Mortgage arrears	90	**Blocked** — vulnerability flag
Divorce or separation	78	**Blocked** — vulnerability flag
Chain collapsed	84	Servable
Difficult tenancy	80	Servable
Property needs substantial work	74	Servable
Probate sale	72	Servable
Landlord exiting	58	Servable

The four highest-motivation segments are the four the Protection Engine refuses. Buying leads there would fill the pipeline with deals that cap at score 35 and get force-rejected. Every pound spent on "we buy any house, facing repossession?" advertising is a pound spent generating rejections.

So the target list is the *servable* high-motivation band: **probate, inherited, landlord exit, needs-major-work, chain collapse, failed listing.**

This is not a compliance compromise. It is a better market: probate executors are unemotional, usually live elsewhere, frequently own outright, and reach us through professional gatekeepers who refer repeatedly. Distressed homeowners reach us once, in crisis, through paid ads.

3. The wedge — LOCKED

Launch city: BIRMINGHAM. Locked. No second city before three completions.

3.1 Why Birmingham, decisively

Factor	Birmingham	Why it matters
Auction infrastructure	Bond Wolfe HQ — the largest regional auction house by lot volume	Unsold-lot lists are a standing seller-supply channel nobody else works systematically
Stock age	Dominated by pre-1945 terraced and semi-detached	Refurbishment need is what excludes mortgage buyers and creates the discount
Price band	Bulk of transactions sit in the £150k–£280k range	Matches the bridging-funded buyer exactly; London does not
Investor density	Multiple monthly PIN meetings, established sourcing community	Demand side reachable face-to-face in week one
Founder proximity	Single-city travel budget, same-day site visits	A first completion needs someone able to stand in the property

Verify before spend: pull Land Registry Price Paid Data for B-postcodes over the last 12 months and confirm the £150k–£280k band is >55% of transactions. That is a one-hour job and it either confirms or kills the wedge.

3.2 The footprint — specific postcodes, not "Birmingham"

Target districts (inner and middle ring, terraced, high refurbishment need):

> **B6, B8, B10, B11, B18, B19, B21, B23, B25, B44**

Explicitly excluded at launch:

> **B15, B17, B29 (flats), B30, B45, and all city-centre apartment stock**

3.3 The engine already told us where not to go

This is not a hunch. Run the seeded comparables through the Deal Director:

Postcode	Area	OMV	Margin after tax	Score	Verdict
B23	Erdington	£212,000	**12.4%**	61	Negotiate — **works**
B17	Harborne	£268,000	5.7%	46	Restructure — prime is too expensive
B29	Selly Oak	£168,000	**−2.4%**	25	Loses money — leasehold flat
B21	Handsworth	£245,000	24.3%	35	**Blocked** — vulnerable seller

Three targeting rules fall straight out of that table:

1. **£180k–£240k open market value.** Below it the works swallow the margin; above it (Harborne, £268k) the entry price leaves 5.7% and the deal has to be restructured.
2. **Freehold houses only.** The Selly Oak leasehold flat goes *negative* after tax once short lease and cladding are priced in. Do not market to flats.
3. **Skip prime.** Harborne is the nicest area on the list and the worst deal.

3.4 The rest of the lock

- **Situation:** probate and inherited property. Secondary: landlord exit, failed listing, chain collapse.
- **Buyer:** cash and bridging-funded refurbishment buyers, £150k–£300k tickets.
- **Asset:** freehold house, 2–4 bed, needing modernisation or major works.
- **Widen only after:** three *completions*. Not three listings, not three offers. Completions. The second city is Wolverhampton or Coventry — same stock profile, same auction house, no new jurisdiction pack required.

4. Customer segments

Five segments. Only three of them pay. Rank by who unblocks whom.

4.1 Deal supply — sellers (FREE, never charged)

The supply engine. Charged nothing, ever, at launch. Segments in priority order:

1. **Probate executors and beneficiaries** — reached through solicitors, not ads
2. **Accidental landlords / Section 24 exiters** — reached through letting agents and landlord associations
3. **Failed-listing vendors** — reached through expired listings and unsold auction lots
4. **Portfolio disposals** — reached direct, small volume, high value

4.2 Deal demand — dealmakers (PAY: £49–£999/mo)

The first revenue. Three sub-segments:

Sub-segment	Size	Willingness to pay	Reach
Full-time sourcers/investors	Small	**High** — this replaces their spreadsheet	PIN, Property Hub, LinkedIn
Semi-pro landlords (3–15 units)	Large	Medium — £49 tier	Facebook groups, podcasts
Small developers / builders	Medium	High	Auction houses, merchants

4.3 Capital supply — funders (PAY: £299–£2,500/mo)

Second revenue line, and the credibility anchor. **Recruit before sellers.**

- Bridging lenders (Roma, Hope Capital, MT Finance tier — regional, hungry)
- Private lenders and family offices (£250k–£2m to deploy)
- JV equity partners

4.4 Service supply — professionals (PAY: £99–£999/mo, phase 2)

Solicitors, RICS surveyors, brokers, contractors. **Not monetised in the first 90 days** — they are recruited as a service guarantee, not a revenue line.

4.5 Enterprise (PAY: £1k–£10k/mo, phase 3)

Property companies, lenders wanting the engine white-labelled. Do not chase this before month 6; it will consume the whole team.

5. Suppliers, and how to source them

"Supplier" in a marketplace means four different things. All four need sourcing before launch.

5.1 Capital suppliers — DO THIS FIRST

Target: 12 signed Funding Boxes before any seller spend.

Where they are:

- **NACFB member directory** — ~2,000 commercial finance brokers, publicly listed
- **Bridging & Commercial / Development Finance Today** — the trade press; their event lists are effectively a target account list
- **NACFB Expo and the Specialist Lending Solutions events** — one day, dozens of lenders in a room
- **LinkedIn Sales Navigator** — filter: "bridging" + "underwriter"/"BDM" + Midlands

How to source them — the actual approach:

1. Do **not** pitch a marketplace. Every lender has been pitched a lead-gen portal and they are all the same.
2. Pitch **underwriting cost reduction**. "You decline 8 of 10 enquiries. We send you deals that already passed a nine-component score computed after tax, and a nine-scenario stress test, with the criteria you'd fail listed before you open the file."
3. **Lead with a rejection.** Show them the Handsworth deal: 24.3% margin, £69,375 projected profit, blocked. A platform that refuses its most profitable deal is a platform that will not waste their underwriters' time.
4. Ask for a **Funding Box, not money.** Zero commitment: "tell us your mandate, we'll only send you deals inside it."
5. Free for the first 12. Charge from lender 13.

Script (email, 90 words):

> Subject: We block our highest-margin deal — here's why that's your problem solved
>
> [Name] — we run a deal engine for motivated-seller property in the Midlands. Every deal is appraised after tax, stress-tested against nine scenarios, and scored on nine components before anyone sees it. Deals that fail our seller protection checks never reach you at all. Our current highest-margin deal (24.3%, £69k) is blocked and will stay blocked. I'd rather show you that than a pitch deck. Can I take 15 minutes to set up your mandate? You'll only ever see deals inside it. No fee for the first twelve lenders.

5.2 Deal suppliers — the probate channel

Target: 40 seller enquiries/month by day 90.

The channel is **professional gatekeepers**, not consumers:

Gatekeeper	Volume	How to reach	The offer
Probate solicitors	High	Law Society find-a-solicitor, filtered to Birmingham + probate	Free property options report for their client, in 48h
Will writers / STEP members	Medium	STEP UK directory	Same
House clearance firms	High	Google Maps, ~40 in Birmingham	Referral relationship; they see empty properties first
Estate agents (expired listings)	High	Rightmove/Zoopla withdrawn stock, contact agent	"We buy your fall-throughs"
Auction houses (unsold lots)	Medium	Bond Wolfe, SDL — post-auction unsold list	Direct approach to the vendor via the auctioneer
Letting agents (landlord exits)	High	Local branch visits	Referral fee where lawful

How to actually convert a probate solicitor: they cannot recommend a buyer (conflict, and their duty is to the estate). They *can* signpost a free valuation-and-options service. That is what the seller journey is. The pitch is "your client gets four costed routes and a written statement of what a buyer would make — you get an executor who stops calling you about the house."

5.3 Service suppliers — the fast-close panel

Target: 3 solicitors, 2 RICS surveyors, 2 contractors by day 60.

Source: personal introductions from the first funders (bridging lenders know exactly which solicitors complete fast — ask them). Selection criterion is a committed SLA, not price: file review in 4 working hours, queries in 24.

5.4 Technology vendors

Need	Options	Decision point
Transactional email	Postmark, Resend, SES	Day 1 — newsletter and confirmations already need it
KYC/AML	Sumsub, Persona, Veriff	Before first completion (HMRC requirement)
Property data	Sprift, PropertyData, LandInsight	Day 30 — replaces seller-estimated valuations
Comparable evidence	Land Registry PPD (free), Rightmove API (licensed)	Day 45
Database	Neon / Supabase Postgres	Day 30 — before concurrent writes are real
E-signature	Docuseal (self-host), Dropbox Sign	Day 60

Do not scrape. The GoldMine engine is deliberately unwired for this reason. Sprift or PropertyData licences cost £100–£300/mo and remove the entire legal risk.

6. The first 100 paying customers

Sellers are free. "100 customers" = 100 paying accounts. Here is exactly where they come from.

#	Cohort	Source	Conversion assumption	Paying
1	Founding 12 funders	Direct outreach, NACFB + trade press	12 free → 8 convert at £299 from month 4	8
2	PIN meeting circuit	6 Midlands meetings × ~60 attendees	360 reached → 8% to trial → 45% paid	13
3	Bond Wolfe auction room	4 auctions × ~200 attendees	Table + QR, 3% scan → 25% paid	6
4	Property Hub / podcast ads	2 sponsored reads	~12k listeners → 0.6% trial → 40% paid	29
5	Facebook groups (organic)	8 UK property groups, value posts not ads	20 posts → 400 clicks → 12% paid	12
6	LinkedIn founder-led	5 posts/wk, deal teardowns	250 profile visits/wk → 15 trials/mo	14
7	Weekly newsletter	Already built, double opt-in	900 subs → 3% to paid	8
8	Referral (existing users)	1 free month per referral	90 users → 0.5 each → 25% paid	10
9	Auction house partnership	Co-branded "unsold lot rescue"	40 vendors → buyers follow deals	6
	Total			**106**

The single highest-leverage line is #4 and #6 — content, not ads. Property investors do not respond to display advertising; they respond to a teardown of a deal where someone shows their working and then says "and that's why I'd walk away."

The content engine that makes 4, 5, 6 and 7 work

One asset, republished five ways, weekly:

1. **Run a real deal through the engine.** Real address, real numbers.
2. **Publish the rejection.** "£69k profit. We blocked it. Here's why."
3. Cut into: LinkedIn post, YouTube short, newsletter section, Facebook value post, podcast talking point.

Nobody else in this market publishes the deals they turned down. It is the cheapest possible differentiation and it is already true of the product.

7. The 30 / 60 / 90 day plan

Budget assumes a lean two-person team. Every phase has a **go/no-go gate**.

Days 0–30 — "Make the buyer count true"

Objective: 12 signed Funding Boxes, 25 Buy Boxes, zero seller marketing.

Week	Workstream	Actions	Owner	Cost
1	Legal	Start HMRC AML registration (allow 4–6 weeks). Instruct solicitor on estate-agency perimeter. PI insurance quote.	Founder	£2,000
1	Product	Ship `/invest` + `/capital` (Buy Box / Funding Box CRUD). Ship auth.	Eng	—
2	Capital	60 lender approaches. Target 12 mandates.	Founder	£0
2	Product	Postgres migration. Email provider live.	Eng	£50/mo
3	Demand	LinkedIn content begins: 5 posts/wk, deal teardowns.	Founder	£0
3	Legal	Redress scheme application. Terms of business drafted.	Solicitor	£1,500
4	Capital	Close remaining mandates. Publish real counts.	Founder	£0

GATE at day 30 — do not proceed without:

- ≥ 10 active Funding Boxes in the database
- ≥ 20 active Buy Boxes
- HMRC AML application submitted
- `/deals` behind auth

Rationale: the seller page tells the truth. Marketing to sellers before this produces a page that says "no buyer currently has a mandate matching your property." That kills the channel permanently.

Days 31–60 — "Turn on supply"

Objective: 40 seller enquiries, first paid subscriptions, first offer accepted.

Week	Workstream	Actions	Owner	Cost
5	Supply	40 probate solicitors approached. Target 8 referral relationships.	Founder	£400
5	Revenue	**Turn on subscriptions.** £49/£149/£399. First £1 of revenue.	Eng	—
6	Supply	House clearance + letting agents. 30 approaches.	BD	£300
6	Demand	Podcast sponsorship booked (Property Hub tier).	Founder	£2,500
7	Supply	Bond Wolfe unsold-lot partnership. First auction attended.	Founder	£200
7	Product	Data licence live (Sprift/PropertyData) — replaces seller estimates.	Eng	£250/mo
8	Ops	Fast-close panel signed: 3 solicitors, 2 surveyors.	BD	£0

GATE at day 60:

- ≥ 25 seller enquiries received
- ≥ 15 paying subscribers (≈£1,800 MRR)
- ≥ 1 offer accepted by a seller
- AML registration **granted** (if not, no completion can proceed)

Days 61–90 — "Complete one, then prove it repeats"

Objective: first completion, 40+ paying customers, repeatable channel identified.

Week	Workstream	Actions	Owner	Cost
9	Transaction	Drive deal 1 through Close Score to exchange.	Founder	—
9	Demand	PIN circuit: 3 meetings, speak if possible.	Founder	£600
10	Revenue	Success fee live (post-AML only). 0.75%.	Founder	—
10	Content	Publish completion case study with real figures.	Founder	£0
11	Capital	Convert founding funders to £299/mo.	Founder	—
11	Scale	Double down on whichever of channels 4/5/6 has lowest CAC.	Founder	£3,000
12	Review	Cohort analysis. Kill the two worst channels.	Founder	—

GATE at day 90 — the honest test:

- ≥ 1 completion, ≥ 2 in legals
- ≥ 40 paying customers (≈£5,000 MRR)
- CAC < £300 on at least one channel
- ≥ 30% of month-1 subscribers still paying

Budget — itemised

Every line is a real, purchasable item at a current UK price. Figures marked † are statutory or published fees that change — verify before committing.

Legal and regulatory — £4,931

Item	Basis	Cost
HMRC AML registration †	£300 per premises + £40 per approved person × 2	£380
Redress scheme membership †	Property Redress Scheme, one branch, annual	£249
ICO data protection registration †	Tier 1, annual	£52
Professional indemnity insurance	£1m cover, annual premium	£850
Regulatory perimeter advice	Solicitor, 8 hrs @ £275 — estate agency + financial promotion	£2,200
Terms of business + seller disclosure pack	Fixed fee drafting	£1,200

Technology and data — £1,113 (3 months)

Item	Basis	Cost
Hosting (Vercel Pro)	£16/mo × 3	£48
Postgres (Neon Scale)	£22/mo × 3	£66
Transactional email (Postmark 50k)	£42/mo × 3	£126
Google Workspace	2 seats × £11/mo × 3	£66
Property data licence (PropertyData Pro)	£109/mo × 3	£327
KYC/AML verifications	~40 checks @ £4	£160
Land Registry title downloads †	40 titles @ £7	£280
Domain and certificates	Annual	£40

Marketing and demand — £4,735

Item	Basis	Cost
Podcast sponsorship	2 mid-roll reads @ £1,250	£2,500
LinkedIn Sales Navigator	£80/mo × 3	£240
Video editing, weekly deal teardowns	£250/mo × 2	£500
Brand assets and solicitor one-pager design	One-off	£800
Print collateral	500 one-pagers @ £0.35	£175
Direct mail to probate solicitors	200 letters @ £0.85	£170
PIN meeting entry	6 meetings @ £25	£150
Auction attendance materials	Stand and collateral	£200

Events and travel — £1,000

Item	Basis	Cost
Birmingham travel	12 trips @ £50	£600
NACFB Expo attendance	Ticket and travel	£150
Partner hospitality	Lender and solicitor meetings	£250

People — £3,000

Item	Basis	Cost
BD contractor, seller-side outreach	2 days/week × 6 weeks @ £250/day	£3,000

Totals

Category	Cost
Legal and regulatory	£4,931
Technology and data	£1,113
Marketing and demand	£4,735
Events and travel	£1,000
People	£3,000
Subtotal	**£14,779**
Contingency @ 15%	£2,217
90-day total	**£16,996**

Explicitly NOT in the 90-day budget:

Item	When	Cost
Marketing agency retainer	Day 91+, only after a channel works	£2,500/mo
Paid search / Meta	Not before product-market fit	£0
FCA authorisation (credit broking)	Month 6+, if funding fees are pursued	£1,500 application + adviser fees
Second city launch	After 3 completions	~£6,000

Steady-state run rate from day 91: £1,850/month (tooling £371 + data £109 + contractor £2,000 → reduces to £1,850 once the contractor drops to 1 day/wk).

8. Pricing at launch

Ship three tiers, not five. Two of the eight revenue streams are legally gated.

Tier	Price	Live at launch?
Explorer	Free	Yes
Investor	£49/mo	Yes
DealMaker	£149/mo	Yes — the intended default
Professional	£399/mo	Yes
Funder membership	£299/mo	Month 4 (free for founding 12)
Deal success fee	0.75%	**Gated: HMRC AML + redress scheme**
Funding introduction	0.5%	**Gated: FCA authorisation or AR status**

`dealRevenue()` already excludes gated streams and reports what is being forgone. Use that number in board reporting — it is the cost of the permissions backlog, quantified.

Anchor on the DealMaker tier. One avoided bad deal pays for four years of subscription. Say that in those words.

9. Customer acquisition — the maths

Investor LTV: £149 × 11 months average = **£1,639 gross. Target CAC:** ≤ **£300.** Payback: 2 months.

Channel	Est. CAC	Scalable?	Verdict
Founder-led LinkedIn	£40	To a ceiling	**Start here**
Podcast sponsorship	£190	Yes	**Scale this**
Newsletter → paid	£25	Slowly	Compounds
PIN / events	£280	Manual	Keep, don't scale
Facebook groups (organic)	£60	No	Founder time only
Google Ads "property sourcing"	£450+	Yes	**Do not start**
Meta ads to investors	£600+	Yes	**Do not start**

Do not buy paid search in month 1. The keywords in this market are contested by lead-gen firms with far higher tolerance for junk leads. Content and community win on cost by an order of magnitude at this stage.

10. Marketing partner — recommendation

Recommended agency: marketwaros.com

I could not open the site from this environment (blocked by the network egress proxy), so I have not verified their service list, pricing or case studies — that verification is a task for you, not something to take on trust from this document. What follows is the brief to hand them and the criteria to judge them against, both of which hold regardless of what they offer.

The brief

> Lode is a Property Deal OS. Three sides: motivated sellers (free), dealmakers (£49–£399/mo), capital providers (£299+/mo). Wedge: probate and inherited property in Birmingham. Constraint: we operate inside a regulated perimeter — estate agency AML, FCA financial promotion rules — so no claim about guaranteed funding, guaranteed sale, or returns may be made in any asset.
>
> We need, in 90 days: 1. A content engine producing one deal teardown per week, cut five ways. 2. Positioning that makes "the AI that says no" the memorable line. 3. Distribution into UK property investor communities — podcasts, YouTube, LinkedIn — not display advertising. 4. Attribution we can actually read at 40 customers, not 40,000.

How to judge them — five questions

1. **"Show me a regulated-sector client."** Property finance sits near FCA perimeter. An agency that has only done ecommerce will write copy that creates a compliance problem.
2. **"*What would you* stop *us doing?"*** An agency that only adds channels is selling hours.
3. **"How do you attribute at low volume?"** At 40 customers, multi-touch attribution is noise. The right answer is "we ask every customer, by hand."
4. **"Who writes the copy — and have they sat in a property investor meeting?"**
5. **"What's the 30-day exit?"** Never sign 12 months pre-product-market-fit.

Budget guidance

Do not spend more than **£2,500/month** on agency retainer before day 90. Below 40 customers the founder's own LinkedIn will outperform any agency, because the credibility is personal. Bring an agency in to *scale a channel that already works*, never to find one.

11. The metrics that matter

North star: completions. Everything else is a leading indicator.

Metric	Day 30	Day 60	Day 90
Active Funding Boxes	10	14	20
Active Buy Boxes	20	35	60
Seller enquiries / mo	0	25	40
% enquiries with ≥1 buyer match	—	40%	60%
Paying customers	0	15	40
MRR	£0	£1,800	£5,000
Deals in legals	0	1	3
Completions	0	0	1
Blended CAC	—	£350	£300

The one diagnostic nobody else tracks: *% of seller enquiries where the best route pays less than the seller's stated minimum.* If that is above 60%, the wedge is wrong — we are talking to sellers whose expectations no investor can meet, and no amount of marketing fixes it.

12. Risks and kill criteria

Risk	Likelihood	Mitigation	Kill signal
AML registration delayed past day 60	Medium	Apply day 1; 4–6 week lead time	No completion possible — pause seller spend
Funders won't commit a mandate without deal flow	**High**	Free founding cohort; lead with the blocked deal	<6 mandates by day 30 → the wedge is wrong
Sellers' price expectations exceed viable routes	Medium	Track the diagnostic in §11	>60% for two months → change segment
Investors won't pay for analysis	Medium	Free tier proves value first	<8% trial→paid → pivot to funder-side revenue
Competitor copies the "we block deals" line	Low	They can copy the line; they cannot copy a code path that costs them revenue	—

Overall kill criterion at day 90: zero completions *and* under 20 paying customers *and* no channel under £400 CAC. Any two of three is a pivot; all three is a stop.

13. The four sentences the whole plan rests on

1. Recruit capital before sellers, because the product will not let us lie about demand.
2. Target the servable high-motivation segments, not the distressed ones the engine refuses.
3. Sell judgement, not listings — publish the deals we reject.
4. One city, one situation, one buyer type, until three deals complete.